

Indian Administrative Service IAS

District Collectors: Selection, Assignment, Career Progression & Tenure

Research Guide

A research guide to official Government of India documents

Sources: DoPT · UPSC · LBSNAA · IAS Cadre Rules 1954 · Pay Rules 2016





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Overview: The Indian Administrative Service

The Indian Administrative Service (IAS) is the premier administrative arm of the All India Services of the Government of India. Established in 1946 (succeeding the Indian Imperial Service of 1893–1946), it is one of the three All India Services alongside the Indian Police Service (IPS) and the Indian Forest Service (IFS). Members serve both the Government of India and individual state governments throughout their careers.

IAS officers are deployed across the full spectrum of Indian governance: district administration, state secretariats, Union ministry departments, public sector undertakings, regulatory bodies, and international organisations such as the World Bank, IMF, and the United Nations.

Key Characteristics

Permanent service	IAS is a career-long service — officers serve across dozens of postings over 30+ years.
Political neutrality	As part of the permanent bureaucracy, IAS officers remain neutral across changes in elected government.
Presidential appointment	All IAS officers, regardless of mode of entry, are appointed by the President of India.
Three entry modes	Direct UPSC recruitment (majority), promotion from State Civil Services, and rare non-state civil service selection.
2:1 direct-to-promotee ratio	The ratio of direct recruits to promotees is fixed at 2:1 by the Recruitment Rules.

Official document: All India Services Act, 1951

The constitutional foundation for the IAS, IPS, and IFS.
Available at: [India Code \(indiacode.nic.in\)](http://indiacode.nic.in) and [DoPT \(dopt.gov.in\)](http://dopt.gov.in)

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Selection: How IAS Officers Are Recruited

The UPSC Civil Services Examination (CSE)

The principal route into the IAS is the Civil Services Examination conducted annually by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC). It is widely considered one of the most competitive examinations in the world, attracting hundreds of thousands of applicants for fewer than 200 IAS seats each year.

Stage 1 — Preliminary

Two objective-type papers (GS Paper I + CSAT). Qualifying in nature — marks not counted for final ranking. Conducted in June each year.

Stage 2 — Mains

Nine written papers (four GS papers, one essay, two optional subject papers, one language paper, and one English paper). Rigorous analytical and descriptive writing assessed. Conducted in September–October.

Stage 3 — Personality Test

Interview by a UPSC board testing suitability for a career in public service — assessing judgment, intellectual curiosity, ethical grounding, and communication. Typically 250–275 marks.

Promotion from State Civil Services

Officers of State Civil Services (PCS/SCS) who have served for 8+ years in the Junior Time Scale become eligible to be considered for the IAS through a Selection Committee process. After 20+ years, they may be directly promoted. These officers undergo an Induction Training Programme at LBSNAA before being confirmed in the IAS.

Official document: IAS (Recruitment) Rules, 1954

Governs all modes of entry into the IAS, the 2:1 direct-to-promotee ratio, and conditions for promotion from State Civil Services.

URL: upsc.gov.in (Appendices > AIS Branch) | dopt.gov.in

Official document: IAS (Appointment by Promotion) Regulations, 1955

Lays down the Selection Committee composition and criteria for promoting State Civil Service officers to the IAS.

URL: upsc.gov.in/about-us/divisions/all-india-services-ais-branch/appendices

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Cadre Allocation: Assigning Officers to States

A 'cadre' is the state or group of states/union territories where an IAS officer serves throughout most of their career. Cadre allocation is administered by the Department of Personnel & Training (DoPT) and determines a lifetime posting geography for the officer.

The Five-Zone System (Cadre Allocation Policy 2017)

From the Civil Services Examination 2017 onwards, India's 26 state/joint cadres are grouped into five geographic zones. Candidates rank zones (and then cadres within each zone) in order of preference before allocation. The policy aims to promote national integration by reducing home-state postings.

Zone	State Cadres	Region
Zone I	Jammu & Kashmir*, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, AGMUT	North-west
Zone II	Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha	Central-east
Zone III	Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh	West-central
Zone IV	Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh*, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu	South/West
Zone V	Telangana*, West Bengal, Assam-Meghalaya, Sikkim, Manipur, Nagaland, Tripura, Mizoram, Arunachal Pradesh	North-east & East

* Jammu & Kashmir cadre was removed in 2019; Andhra Pradesh and Telangana cadres reflect bifurcation.

Insider / Outsider Ratio

Each cadre maintains a 1:2 insider-to-outsider ratio — only one-third of officers in any cadre may be from the home state. To be allocated to a home cadre, a candidate must: (1) rank their home-state zone as first preference, (2) specifically indicate their home cadre, and (3) have sufficient merit rank and available insider vacancy in their category.

Allocation Procedure

- DoPT (for IAS), MHA (for IPS), and MoEFCC (for IFoS) determine annual cadre vacancies — unreserved and reserved — before the CSE result.
- Selected candidates submit zone + cadre preferences in rank order (one cadre per zone per round).
- Allocation runs in 25-candidate rotation cycles, balancing merit with declared preferences and vacancy availability.
- Candidates who do not submit preferences are allocated alphabetically to remaining vacancies.
- Final cadre list is published by DoPT on cseplus.dopt.gov.in after the CSE final result.

Official document: IAS (Cadre) Rules, 1954 + Cadre Allocation Policy 2017

IAS (Cadre) Rules 1954: [latestlaws.com](https://www.latestlaws.com) | mahaias.maharashtra.gov.in
 Cadre Allocation Policy 2017: cseplus.dopt.gov.in (official DoPT portal)
 Rule 9 specifically governs who may hold a cadre post (e.g. Collector).

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Training: From Probationer to Field Officer

Successful UPSC candidates undergo an intensive ~2-year training programme before their first substantive district posting. All training is conducted under the IAS (Probation) Rules and the IAS Probationer's Final Examination Regulations, 1955. The Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA) in Mussoorie, Uttarakhand, is the apex training institution.

Foundation Course (~15 weeks)

Conducted at LBSNAA for all recruits to All India Services, IFS, and Central Services. Covers Public Administration, Law, Economics, the Constitution, and Management (~400 teaching hours). Builds esprit de corps across services. Ends with a Common Final Examination.

Phase I — Academic (12 weeks)

IAS-specific training at LBSNAA. Five subjects: Law, Basic Economic Principles & Indian Economy, Political Concepts & Constitution, Management & Behavioural Sciences, and Public Administration. Emphasis on public systems management.

Bharat Darshan (7 weeks)

Winter Study Tour traversing ~20,000 km across India in small groups (18–20 OTs). Attachments with armed forces, PSUs, tribal areas, NGOs, e-governance institutions, and the Lok Sabha Secretariat. Builds pan-India perspective and cultural literacy.

District Training (~52 weeks)

Immersive in-field training in the assigned cadre state. Attachments at Collectorate, Zila Parishad, SDM/Tehsildar offices, SSP, courts, CMO, DFO, Municipal Corporation, and BDPO. Officers hold independent charge of 2–3 sub-posts (BDPO: 4–8 weeks, Tehsildar: 4–8 weeks). Supervised by the District Collector.

Phase II — Advanced (~6 weeks)

Officers return to LBSNAA to share district learning. Advanced sessions on policy making, land management, national security, e-governance, project management, and soft skills. Discussions with distinguished practitioners and policy experts.

Central Secretariat (~13 weeks)

All IAS probationers are posted as Assistant Secretaries in Union Ministries under Joint Secretaries. Officers work on a policy project presented up the chain to the Cabinet Secretary and, for the best projects, to the Prime Minister.

Official document: Training documents

LBSNAA Phase I curriculum: lbsnaa.gov.in/menu/ias-phase-i

IAS (Probation) Rules: dopt.gov.in

IAS Probationer's Final Examination Regulations, 1955: dopt.gov.in

Mid-Career Training Programme (MCTP): lbsnaa.gov.in — covers Phases III-V

5 Career Progression & The Collector Posting

The IAS career follows a well-defined ladder of increasing responsibility, alternating between field postings (district and division level) and secretariat postings (state capital and New Delhi). Promotions are time-bound but also dependent on annual performance appraisals, departmental examinations, and vacancy availability.

- Yr 0–2

Foundation & Induction Training

Probationer

15-week Foundation Course at LBSNAA (Mussoorie) covering Law, Economics, Constitution, Management, and Public Administration. Followed by Phase I (12-week academics + 7-week Bharat Darshan national tour). Central Secretariat posting as Assistant Secretary for ~3 months.
- Yr 1–4

Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM)

Junior Time Scale

First substantive field posting after probation. Officer is executive magistrate for a sub-division of 7–8 blocks. Responsible for land revenue, law & order, and developmental administration. Works under mentorship of District Collector. Basic pay: ₹56,100 at entry.
- Yr 4–9

Additional District Magistrate (ADM)

Senior Time Scale

Promoted after ~4 years. Typical postings: ADM, CEO Zilla Parishad, Chief Development Officer (CDO), or Sub-Divisional Officer. Assists the District Collector across revenue, development, and law & order functions.
- Yr 9–14

District Collector / District Magistrate

JAG / Selection Grade

The hallmark field posting of the IAS career. Head of entire district administration. Powers span revenue collection, law & order, elections, disaster management, and developmental schemes. Typical tenure: 2–3 years per district. Basic pay: ₹78,800–₹1,18,500.
- Yr 14–18

Divisional Commissioner / State Secretary

Super Time Scale

Officer either oversees a revenue division (3–8 districts) as Divisional Commissioner, or moves to state secretariat as Secretary/Principal Secretary of a department. Alternatively, may go on Central Deputation as Director or Joint Secretary in a Union Ministry.
- Yr 18–25

Principal Secretary / Additional CS / Joint Secy

Higher Admin Grade

Senior policy-making role at state level (Principal Secretary, Addl. Chief Secretary) or at Centre (Additional Secretary in Ministry). Involved in bilateral/multilateral negotiations, legislative drafting, and budget oversight.



Yr 25+

Chief Secretary / Cabinet Secretary

Apex Scale

Chief Secretary is the senior-most civil servant in a State, heading all departments and serving as bridge between Council of Ministers and bureaucracy. Cabinet Secretary is the apex civil servant of India (Pay Level 18), coordinating all Union Ministries and advising the Prime Minister.

Official document: IAS (Pay) Rules 2016 + Promotion framework

IAS (Pay) Rules 2016: dopt.gov.in — governs pay levels for each grade.

IAS Promotion Chart: DoPT circular on grade/time-bound promotion norms.

IAS (Seniority) Rules 1987: dopt.gov.in — seniority for empanelment decisions.

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The District Collector: Powers & Responsibilities

The District Collector (also called District Magistrate in north India and Deputy Commissioner in some southern and north-eastern states) is the single most visible and powerful field position in Indian governance. The post concentrates administrative, revenue, magisterial, and developmental authority at the district level.

Revenue Administration

- Head of all land revenue administration in the district.
- Presides over revenue courts (settlement, partition, mutation).
- Oversees Survey and Settlement operations.
- Statutory authority under the State Land Revenue Code.

Law & Order / Magisterial

- Senior-most Executive Magistrate in the district under CrPC.
- Powers under Sections 107, 144, 151 CrPC for preventive action.
- Superintendence over the District Police (advisory, not command).
- Chairs the District Peace Committee during communal tension.

Developmental Administration

- District Planning Committee Chair — prepares district plan.
- Implements all Central and State government schemes at grass-roots.
- Oversees MGNREGS, PMGSY, PM Awas Yojana, Jal Jeevan Mission, etc.
- Controls District Mineral Foundation and CAMPA funds.

Disaster Management

- District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) Chair under DM Act 2005.
- First responder for floods, droughts, cyclones, earthquakes.
- Coordinates NDRF, SDRF, police, health, and PWD during relief.
- Prepares District Disaster Management Plan annually.

Electoral Duties

- District Election Officer for all elections in the district.
- Returning Officer for one or more Assembly/Parliamentary constituencies.
- Coordinates voter roll revision, booth management, and results.
- Works directly under Election Commission of India during elections.

Coordination Hub

- Interface between State Government and local administration.
- Chairs all departmental coordination meetings in the district.

- Single point of contact for Chief Minister's / CM's Office direct queries.
- Supervises district-level offices of all line departments.

Official document: Key statutes governing Collector powers

Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) 1973 — magisterial powers.

State Land Revenue Codes (e.g. MLRC for Maharashtra, UP Revenue Code) — revenue powers.

Disaster Management Act 2005 — DDMA constitution and emergency powers.

Representation of the People Act 1951 — electoral role.

Government of India policy circulars: dopt.gov.in / respective State government sites.

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Tenure, Transfers & Performance Appraisal

Tenure as District Collector

There is no fixed statutory tenure for the Collector post — tenure is governed by state government orders and DoPT guidelines. In practice, an IAS officer serves 2–3 years as Collector of a given district before being transferred to another district or a secretariat role. Transfers are the prerogative of the State Government.

Rule 9 — Cadre Post Mandatory for IAS

Rule 9 of the IAS (Cadre) Rules, 1954 requires that every cadre post (including the Collector's post) must be held by an IAS cadre officer. A State Government wishing to post a non-IAS officer to a cadre post must obtain prior approval from the Central Government. Exceptions are intended to be short-term and exceptional — not routine practice.

Case example — Rule 9 enforcement

In a 2020 case, DoPT wrote to Nagaland's Chief Secretary citing violation of Rule 9 after six non-IAS officers were posted as Deputy Commissioners (Collectors), noting that IAS officers were available but posted to subordinate ex-cadre positions instead.

Performance Appraisal Report (PAR)

The performance of every IAS officer is assessed annually through the Performance Appraisal Report (PAR), governed by the All India Services (PAR) Rules, 2007. The PAR determines suitability for promotion, empanelment for senior posts, and central deputation eligibility.

Self-appraisal	Officer (Reporting Officer) lists achievements, targets met, and areas for improvement.
First review	Reviewing Officer (immediate superior) adds comments and numerical grading.
Final acceptance	Accepting Authority (senior officer / Secretary-level) conducts final review.
DoPT transmission	All PARs forwarded to DoPT for central records, empanelment, and promotion decisions.

Central Deputation

After 9 years of cadre service, IAS officers become eligible for Central Deputation to Union Ministries. Under Rule 6(1) of the IAS (Cadre) Rules, 1954, the Central Government may requisition officers from state cadres. Officers may also be deputed under Rule 6(2)(ii) to private organisations, international bodies (World Bank, UN agencies, IMF, ADB), or Central PSUs for fixed terms.

Official document: All India Services (PAR) Rules 2007

Governs the annual performance appraisal cycle for all AIS officers.

URL: dopt.gov.in — search 'AIS PAR Rules 2007'

IAS (Cadre) Rules 1954 Rule 6: governs deputation to Centre and private bodies.

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Official Documents Reference Directory

The table below lists the primary official documents governing the IAS and the District Collector posting, along with the official sources from which they can be accessed.

Document	What it governs	Where to find it
All India Services Act, 1951	Constitutional foundation for IAS, IPS, IFS	indiacode.nic.in dopt.gov.in
IAS (Recruitment) Rules, 1954	Governs all modes of entry; 2:1 ratio; promotion criteria	upsc.gov.in > AIS Branch Appendices dopt.gov.in
IAS (Appointment by Promotion) Regulations, 1955	Selection Committee; State Civil Service to IAS promotion	upsc.gov.in > AIS Branch Appendices
IAS (Cadre) Rules, 1954	Cadre structure, composition, Rule 6 deputation, Rule 9 cadre posts	latestlaws.com mahaias.maharashtra.gov.in iasexamportal.com
Cadre Allocation Policy, 2017	Zone-based cadre allocation, insider-outsider ratio, procedure	cseplus.dopt.gov.in (official DoPT portal) — download PDF
IAS (Probation) Rules	Period and conditions of probation; grounds for discharge	dopt.gov.in lbsnaa.gov.in
IAS Probationer's Final Examination Regulations, 1955	Structure and conduct of LBSNAA examinations	lbsnaa.gov.in/menu/about-lbsnaa
All India Services (PAR) Rules, 2007	Annual performance appraisal; reporting/reviewing/accepting chain	dopt.gov.in — search 'AIS PAR Rules 2007'
IAS (Pay) Rules, 2016	Pay matrix (7th CPC); grade pay levels for each career stage	dopt.gov.in — search 'IAS Pay Rules 2016'
IAS (Seniority) Rules, 1987	Seniority determination for empanelment and promotion	dopt.gov.in latestlaws.com
Disaster Management Act, 2005	DDMA constitution; Collector as DDMA Chair; emergency powers	ndma.gov.in indiacode.nic.in
Representation of the People Act, 1951	Collector's electoral role: District Election Officer, Returning Officer	eci.gov.in indiacode.nic.in
CrPC (Code of Criminal Procedure), 1973	Magisterial powers under Sections 107, 144, 151 etc.	indiacode.nic.in
LBSNAA Training Curriculum	Phase I & II syllabi; Mid-Career Training Programme details	lbsnaa.gov.in/menu/ias-phase-i

Primary web portals to bookmark:

Portal	URL	Best for
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DoPT	dopt.gov.in	All IAS rules, pay rules, PAR rules, cadre allocation — one-stop for all AIS regulations
UPSC	upsc.gov.in	Appendices section under AIS Branch — original gazetted notifications for recruitment and promotion rules
LBSNAA	lbsnaa.gov.in	Training curriculum, Phase I/II details, probation rules, and MCTP details
CSE Plus (DoPT)	cseplus.dopt.gov.in	Official cadre allocation PDFs published after each UPSC Civil Services result
India Code	indiacode.nic.in	All central Acts (All India Services Act 1951, DM Act 2005, RPA 1951, CrPC 1973)
NDMA	ndma.gov.in	Disaster Management Act and DDMA guidelines relevant to Collector role